CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

SOMMELIER IN THE AI ERA

The $75K on the old card was a head sommelier at a top house — roughly the 90th percentile. The beginner's job is waiting tables at $35,230 a year, tips already included.

★ TL;DR — NO. There is no BLS occupation called Sommelier; the anchor is Waiters and Waitresses at $35,230 a year including tips (BLS, May 2025) — so the old $75K was +113% over the occupation a beginner actually enters. The sommelier seat itself is a step-up: postings require Court of Master Sommeliers Certified (level 2 of 4) or WSET Level 2+ plus prior sommelier or beverage-management experience, and head roles ask 3–5 years as a sommelier. Aggregators put working sommeliers at ~$43–58K (ZipRecruiter $43,449; Salary.com $58,303) — below the card even after the climb. The doors below pay for the same palate sooner. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$35K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

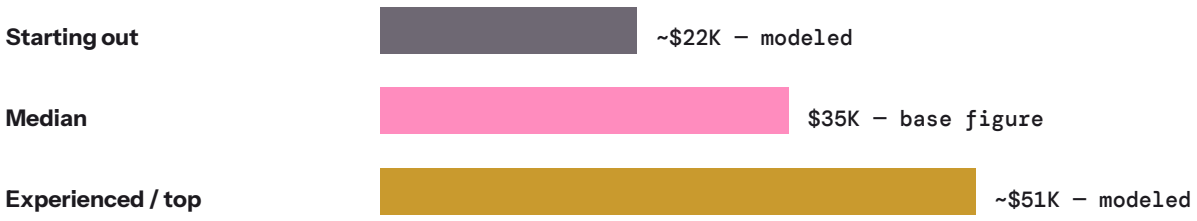
- Fails as a start because: there is no beginner sommelier job. The first job is server, barback or cellar assistant, paid as one — $35,230 median including tips, bottom decile under $8.70/hr including tips.

- The seats are scarce and concentrating: ~150 employers hiring for sommelier roles on Indeed against 423,100 waiter openings a year; casual and mid-market dining has been folding wine service into server and manager roles for a decade.

- The information half of the job is commoditised: Vivino's 70M+ users scan labels and wine lists for free, and shrinking wine lists (hundreds of bottles down to a few dozen) shrink the seat with them.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Sommelier is a ~$35K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A SOMMELIER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Build and maintain the wine list and the cellar behind it
- ✓ Recommend, present and pour wine tableside, matched to food and budget
- ✓ Train floor staff on the list; run beverage inventory and margins
- ✓ Hold supplier and allocation relationships for scarce bottles

Think: a librarian for a cellar who also has to sell the books, nightly, to people holding a menu upside down.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
No robot pours. The automation is substitution of the knowledge layer: wine apps (Vivino, Delectable) and AI inventory/demand tools cover casual recommendation and cellar admin — the part of the role that existed outside fine dining.	Tableside judgment in fine dining: reading a table, a budget and a dish in seconds; cellar management and allocation relationships. Real, human — and confined to a small number of rooms.

⚠ **Know what the 'licence' actually is: CMS and WSET are private, voluntary certifications — they gate prestige, not legality. The permit that legally gates the work is state alcohol-server training (California RBS, Washington MAST, Oregon OLCC, Illinois BASSET), a flat course of hours. Budget your years for floor experience — 2–4 years before a first real sommelier seat — not for exam fees.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ The surviving core is genuinely skilled and human: fine-dining cellar work is not being automated ✓ Wine knowledge compounds — every service teaches the list, the regions, the buyers ✓ The same palate and sales craft is hired, sooner and better paid, by restaurants and distributors	✗ Beginner pay is server pay: $35,230 including tips, with a cash base that can be a fraction of it ✗ Certification (level 2 of 4) plus 2–4 years of floor experience stands between you and the title ✗ Mid-market dining keeps deleting the dedicated seat; the gigs concentrate in a few fine-dining cities

Good fit? You love wine and hospitality and will work the floor for years — aimed at the seats where that love is paid first.
Bad fit? You priced your life on $75K, or planned to certificate your way past the server years.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Restaurant Manager	DOOR B — PIVOT TO B2B Sales Rep
The room you already work in, one seat up: Food Service Managers median $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year, formal requirement a high school diploma plus less than 5 years of related experience. The ladder is printed — floor ~$35K → supervisor $45,370 → manager $69,390 — and in most restaurants the manager IS the wine programme now: list, margins and staff training included. First move: volunteer to own the wine list's numbers in your current house and present them monthly.	The wine-distribution sales side: the people who sell wine to restaurants instead of pouring it. B2B sales representatives carry a ~$76K median overall (BLS, Wholesale and Manufacturing Sales Representatives) with ~123,400 openings a year — volume an order beyond sommelier postings. Your floor years are the qualification distributors actually want: you know what moves, what dies on a list, and how buyers think. First move: list the ten accounts whose buyers you'd call first, and learn one portfolio deeply enough to pitch it.

Smart move: Sell the palate as a revenue skill, not a credential. Restaurants and distributors pay for wine that moves at margin — the person who can prove attach rates and list performance gets hired over the person with one more certificate.
Where you land after: You land where wine knowledge is a P&L; line — running the room that owns the list, or selling the list to a hundred rooms — at $69–76K anchors instead of server pay.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	TAKE THE	PICK YOUR	CERTIFY IN	BUILD THE	TAKE THE

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Read the BLS Waiters and Waitresses page: $35,230 median including tips — that is your entry occupation
- Read three live sommelier postings and count the gates: certification level plus prior sommelier experience, every time

STEP 2 — Take the floor job with a wine brief

WEEKS 1–4

- Serve in the best wine room that will hire you — the list is your classroom and your reference
- Complete your state's alcohol-server permit (RBS/MAST/OLCC/BASSET type) — hours, and legally required

STEP 3 — Pick your door

MONTH 2

- Door A if you love the room: own the list's numbers and climb to the manager seat that controls it
- Door B if you love the selling: aim at distributor portfolios and account work

STEP 4 — Certify in the right order

MONTHS 2–12

- CMS Introductory/Certified or WSET Level 2 while employed — as a differentiator on top of floor years, not instead of them
- Track your wine sales attach rate and list performance; those numbers are the interview

STEP 5 — Build the buyer network

ONGOING

- Know your distributors' reps by name; they are Door B's hiring pool and Door A's information edge
- Taste systematically and keep notes — a documented palate is a portable asset

STEP 6 — Take the paid seat — whichever door opens first

YEAR 1–2

- Apply to assistant-manager and distributor-rep postings with your numbers in hand
- If a true sommelier seat opens in your room by then, take it from strength — employed, certified, and already selling

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read the BLS waiter wage line, then three sommelier job postings — compare the gates to the pay.

□ Days 1–30: serving in a serious wine room; state alcohol-server permit done.

□ Days 31–60: door chosen; wine-list numbers owned or portfolio study started.

□ Days 61–90: certification underway; attach-rate record running.

□ Day 90: your wine knowledge is attached to revenue — the only form in which this industry pays for it early.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ SELL THE WINE. SKIP THE WAIT. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.